Ignaz Semmelweis — Die Aetiologie (1861)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Ignaz Semmelweis, who stood between two maternity clinics under one Vienna sky and refused to treat their different death rates as fate. The clue came from a colleague's death, and the proof came from washed hands. When Vienna would not prolong his contract, he proved the doctrine again at Pest. This presentation is dedicated to him, and to the mothers whose deaths, counted honestly in his tables, made the argument no reader can unsee.

The author's own terms

His central term is "cadaverous particles," his *Cadavertheile* — decomposed animal-organic matter carried into the body and resorbed. The term is kept as he used it and is not modernised into germs or bacteria, which he did not possess. *Jauche* is rendered "putrid discharge" or "ichor," according to context. "Childbed fever" and "puerperal fever" both render *Kindbettfieber / Puerperalfieber*, kept at their historical breadth and not collapsed into a single modern diagnosis.

The story

Ignaz Semmelweis was born at Buda on 1 July 1818. He began law at Vienna

in 1837, turned to medicine from 1838, and took his medical doctorate at Vienna in 1844. In 1846 he became assistant at the First Obstetrical Clinic of the Vienna General Hospital.

In 1847, after Jakob Kolletschka died from an autopsy cut, Semmelweis made the detection that governs the book: the disease that killed Kolletschka was the disease he had seen kill the mothers, and it was carried to them above all by the examining hand. His Vienna contract was not prolonged, and he left for Pest in 1850. He was honorary senior physician at St. Rochus Hospital from 1851 to 1855, then Professor at Pest until July 1865. He married Maria Weidenhoffer in 1857; they had five children, two of whom died as babies. He died on 13 August 1865, two weeks after admission to the Lower Austrian asylum, of sepsis. The origin of the fatal wound is not established, and older accounts differ; no stronger claim is made here.

The work and what survives

Die Aetiologie, der Begriff und die Prophylaxis des Kindbettfiebers (Pest, Vienna, and Leipzig: C. A. Hartleben, 1861; preface dated Pest, 30 August 1860) is his book-length proof. It is a recognised landmark, cited as Garrison-Morton 6277 and *Printing and the Mind of Man* 316(b2). The German original survives in print and in the Bayerische Staatsbibliothek scan, digital object `bsb10860445`.

The proof begins with the two-clinic contrast of Table I, 1841–46, recomputed from his counts: the First Clinic recorded 20,042 deliveries and 1,989 deaths, 9.92 percent; the Second recorded 17,791 deliveries and 691 deaths, 3.88 percent. Epidemic and shared local causes cannot explain a difference so placed. From mid-May 1847 he required chlorine washing before examination, and the mortality fell. Later cases widened the carrier beyond cadaverous matter to putrid discharge from a living patient, and to impregnated air.

What this project holds is Installment I only: a fresh English rendering of printed pages 38–60, a working draft that has not had independent medical-historical or German review and must not be described as finished. The remainder is mapped in the folder — printed pages 1–37 and 61 to the end — not translated.

Its English fortunes

English translations exist, and no first-translation claim is made. Murphy's translation appeared in *Medical Classics* in 1941 and was reissued in 1981; its own completeness was not collated in the research recorded here, and no more than that is said. Carter's translation (University of Wisconsin Press, 1983) is expressly abridged, at xii + 263 pages.

No complete, unabridged, free English text of this evidentiary core was found after the research recorded in the production notes.

What completing it would take

Completing the work would mean translating the mapped remainder: printed pages 1–37 first, beginning with the page-exact map and count the folder names as the next step, then pages 61 to the end in bounded installments. Before the work may be described as finished it needs the two reviews the folder requires — independent medical-historical review and German-language review. Murphy's extent would also need collation against the German, so the English-status wording can be set at its true strength, and his terms must be kept unmodernised throughout.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/semmelweis-atiologie/semmelweis-atiologie.txt`
- PIN: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-semmelweis.md`
- Bayerische Staatsbibliothek scan, digital object `bsb10860445`
- https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/epidemiology-and-infection/article/semmelweis-and-the-aetiology-of-puerperal-sepsis-160-years-on-an-historical-review/93B60B7A592D3FF29814CF6DEF0926BF
- https://www.springermedizin.at/ignaz-semmelweis-a-victim-of-harassment/17771556